



COCKATIEL · NYMPHICUS HOLLANDICUS

The first parrot, done properly.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: cage setup, a pellet-forward diet and how to get there, night frights, household fumes and feather dust, hens and eggs, and the health pages that decide how long a cockatiel lives.

INSIDE

- ✓ Cage size, bar spacing, and the night light that prevents a real injury
- ✓ Pellet conversion schedules, safe food lists, and the never-feed list
- ✓ Sexing by plumage, reading the crest, and an egg binding page
- ✓ Seven health pages, a symptom table, and fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets

51 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A cockatiel and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read the profile and housing pages, 4 to 11, before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the cage on page 6, which people buy small and then replace, and whether you bring home one cockatiel or two on page 18. Settle both, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 38 to buy once instead of twice.

If your cockatiel is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, then read page 13 if the bird is on a seed mix: diet drives most of the health problems on the health pages, and the change takes days to months, so starting it today matters more than finishing this book first. Then read page 8, because a night light costs almost nothing and prevents the injury this species is known for. If anything looks wrong, go straight to Red Flags on page 29.

Print these first

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|--|--|
| ☐ Page 36: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 43: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 37: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 44: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 40: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 45: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 41: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 46: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

The cockatiel is sold as the easy, gentle first parrot, and much of that is true. A lot of the advice in circulation is not: a seed bowl, a tall narrow cage bought for its looks, and a room left pitch dark all night are still normal advice somewhere, and all three shorten a cockatiel's life or injure it. Every figure here is cross-checked against the veterinary and published sources listed on page 49.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is a vet call, not a page in this book, and a cockatiel hides illness until it is far along. Find an avian vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card.

SECTION 01 • PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Nymphicus hollandicus</i> . The smallest member of the cockatoo family, and the only species in its genus.
Adult size	12 to 13 in (30 to 33 cm) including the tail; 80 to 125 g, about 90 g on average
Captive lifespan	12 to 15 years typically, with up to about 25 reported; the longevity record is 35 years
Native range	Open grassland, scrubland and lightly wooded country across Australia, in nomadic flocks that follow water and seeding grasses
Diet type	Grass seeds, grains, berries and insects in the wild; in captivity 75 to 80% pellets, with vegetables and a little fruit (page 12)
Cage, one bird	About 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm) as the minimum; 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) for easier movement. Wider beats taller.
Bar spacing	Half an inch (1.3 cm) or smaller
Room temperature	About 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), with no drafts and no direct sun on the cage
Darkness and light	10 to 12 hours of quiet, dark sleep every night, with a cover or a small night light against night frights. 10 to 12 hours a day of UV (ultraviolet) light exposure, or safe supervised time outdoors.
Sexing	By plumage in a standard gray adult over 6 months old; most color varieties need a DNA (deoxyribonucleic acid) test (page 25)
Handling difficulty	Beginner, built on trust over 7 to 14 days of settling and short sessions
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$295 to \$601 for a complete starter setup, bird included (\$75 to \$250 of it, depending on the color). The cage is often the biggest single line, more than the bird. Every line is on page 38.

Ongoing

About \$200 to \$350 a year for food, toy replacement and cage upkeep, roughly \$17 to \$29 a month. Avian vet exams come on top, at least once a year.

THE LINE ITEM PEOPLE LEAVE OUT

Avian vets are a specialized field, harder to find and often pricier than a general small-animal clinic. Pet insurance for birds is uncommon, and reproductive emergencies like egg binding arrive with no warning. Set money aside for them from the start.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Cockatiels were the first parrot species to be widely bred in captivity, and remain among the most popular pet birds in the world.
- Males especially learn whistled tunes and will repeat them for hours, and many pick up short phrases too.
- Australia bars the export of its native birds, so every cockatiel kept anywhere else descends from stock that was already outside the country.

The species, colors, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

A small cockatoo

The cockatiel is *Nymphicus hollandicus*, the smallest member of the cockatoo family and endemic to Australia. In the wild it lives in open country and lightly wooded areas across the continent, moving with the water and with whichever grasses are seeding. Like the larger cockatoos it carries a movable crest and produces powder down, a fine feather dust that films the furniture near the cage (page 9). It was the first parrot widely bred in captivity, prized for its gentle temperament, whistling and trainability.

Colors

The normal gray, with a yellow face and orange cheek patches, is the closest color to the wild bird and is usually the cheapest, because it needs no selective breeding to produce. Every other color carries a premium. Four mutations underpin nearly every variety on sale: pied, which appeared in California in 1949, lutino in 1958, cinnamon during the 1950s, and pearl in 1967. Color matters for one practical reason: the plumage sexing method works on the normal gray and fails on most of the rest (page 25). The care in this package applies to every color.

Size and age

Length	12 to 13 in (30 to 33 cm) including the long tail
Weight	80 to 125 g, about 90 g on average. Your own bird's settled weight matters more than the range (page 16).
Weaning	Around 42 to 52 days old. Most pet cockatiels are bought already weaned onto solid food.
Maturity	6 to 12 months. Until about 6 months every young cockatiel is colored like a hen.

Lifespan

12 to 15 years is typical, a well-kept bird can reach about 25, and the longevity record is 35 years for one exceptional bird. Budget for the long end. A cockatiel bought for a 10-year-old can still be on its perch when that child finishes college, and the cage, the avian vet and the daily routine have to last all of those years.

Whistling and noise

Cockatiels are whistlers far more than talkers. They learn and repeat whole melodies, and some pick up a few words, but whistling is the real strength, and males are the ones known for it. Most of the day is whistling and chatter at a volume most households barely register. The exception is a sharp contact call or the well-known wolf whistle, which cuts through a quiet room in short bursts, especially during a hormonal phase. In an apartment with thin walls, weigh that before you buy.

A PREY BIRD FIRST

Wild cockatiels live in flocks where a predator picks off the bird that looks weakest. That one fact explains three things in this book: the bird wants company, it hides illness until it cannot, and a sudden movement in the dark sends it into a panic.

Cage size, bar spacing & placement

The purchase that is hardest to undo, and the one number that is a safety limit.

Size and shape

Reference tables put the minimum for a single cockatiel at about 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm), and many keepers aim for 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) for more comfortable movement. Cage minimums are quoted per bird, so a cage shared by two has to be larger than one sized for a single cockatiel. Prioritize width over height. Cockatiels fly in short, fast, horizontal bursts between perches rather than climbing, so a tall, narrow cage wastes exactly the space the bird would use. A floor-to-ceiling cage can look impressive in a store and still give a cockatiel none of the flight space it needs. A wide flight-style cage is worth the extra footprint.

Bar spacing and bar direction

A SAFETY LIMIT, NOT A PREFERENCE

Bars must be half an inch (1.3 cm) apart or closer. Wider spacing is a genuine and avoidable risk of head entrapment.

Choose vertical bars. When a wing catches between horizontal bars during a flapping bout, the bird can damage it as it struggles free. Check the finish too: galvanized wire is a zinc source, and stainless steel or powder-coated hardware avoids the problem (page 10).

Where the cage goes

PLACE	WHY
Against a wall, at or near eye level	Movement above or behind a caged prey bird reads as a predator. One solid side to back into settles a new bird faster.
Somewhere the household is	Cockatiels are flock birds and need regular interaction. A cage in a room people use gives the bird some of it every day.
Never the kitchen	Overheated nonstick cookware gives off fumes that are rapidly fatal to birds, and the fumes travel beyond the room (page 9).
Off drafts, out of direct sun	A caged bird cannot move out of the sun or away from a cold draft. The room itself should sit at about 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C).
Away from sudden movement outside	Headlights, passing shadows and movement at a window are the triggers for night frights.
Not in your bedroom	The feather dust a cockatiel sheds is a slow risk to the people who breathe it every night.

BUY THE CAGE BEFORE THE BIRD

Set it up and stock it with perches and dishes before pickup day. It is far easier to find a flimsy door catch or a stuck tray with nothing living in the cage, and a cage assembled in a hurry on the day the bird arrives tends to stay as it was built.

Perches, dishes & what to leave out

The inside of the cage does more for the bird than the outside dimensions.

Perches

Provide several perches of varying diameter and texture rather than a uniform set, which supports better foot health over time. Diameters from about 5/8 in to 1.5 in (1.6 to 3.8 cm) suit a cockatiel's foot. A cage of identical dowels puts the same pressure on the same points of the foot all day and gives the bird no reason to move. Natural branch beats plastic.

Place perches at different heights and distances, so crossing the cage takes more than one hop. A bird that stands on rough, varied perches wears its nails down through ordinary use; one confined to smooth dowels needs trims more often (page 22).

TYPE	NOTES
Natural branch	Irregular along its length, so the foot keeps changing its grip
Rope	Check it often. Rope comes out at the first frayed strand, because cockatiels swallow the fibers and matted strands can block the gut.
Sandpaper covers	Leave them out. They damage feet.

Dishes and water

Position food and water dishes so droppings cannot fall into them. Fresh water goes in every day, in a dish washed daily, and stays available all the time. A cockatiel fed seed in a shared cage needs a dish of its own (page 12).

Cuttlebone or mineral block

Keep a cuttlebone or mineral block in the cage at all times. It is a calcium source, which matters most for a hen, and something for the beak to work against. Cockatiels are noted as especially prone to calcium deficiency (page 30).

LEAVE THESE OUT

Grit. Cockatiels hull their seed before swallowing it, so grit has no job to do, and a bird that eats too much of it, a sick bird especially, can end up with a dangerous gut blockage.

Nest-like spaces. Any dark, enclosed hideaway reads as a nest site and is a trigger for chronic egg laying (page 26).

Mirrors. A bird can bond to a mirror or a favorite toy as it would to a mate.

Galvanized metal, and frayed rope or loose threads.

LINE THE TRAY WITH PLAIN PAPER

Plain paper, changed as part of the daily clean, shows the droppings clearly, and the droppings are the cheapest daily health check you have (page 35). A grate over the tray keeps the bird off its own droppings between changes.

Temperature, light, sleep & night frights

A steady room, the right light, real darkness, and the one injury this species is known for.

SETTING	TARGET
Room temperature	About 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C). No drafts, no direct sun on the cage.
Darkness	10 to 12 hours of quiet, dark, uninterrupted sleep every night, at about the same clock time
UV light	10 to 12 hours a day of UV light exposure, or safe supervised time outdoors, supports healthy vitamin D levels
Sick or recovering bird	75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C); birds recover and eat better at the upper end

Why the dark hours matter

A bird reads day length as a season and uses it to decide when to go into breeding condition. A long photoperiod is one of the major breeding triggers, and cockatiels, lovebirds and budgies are the small parrots most often seen as emergencies for reproductive disease. A household that keeps the lamps and the television on until late hands the bird an endless summer.

"Uninterrupted" does real work in that sentence. A bird that gets 11 dark hours but has a hallway light flick on twice is not getting the same rest as one with 11 genuinely dark, quiet hours. A cover on the cage blocks light, but it does nothing about a television's sound or people walking through the room. A smaller sleep cage in a quiet room, used at the same time every night, solves both.

Night frights

Cockatiels are prone to night frights: sudden, panicked flapping in the dark, where a startled bird thrashes inside the cage and can injure itself on the bars. Avian vets in earthquake-prone California have noticed that cockatiels, more than other species, turn up injured the morning after a tremor, and a bird clinic in Melbourne saw cockatiels come in with minor injuries after two small tremors there.

THE FIX COSTS ALMOST NOTHING

A small night light in the room, or a cage cover, helps prevent injuries during these episodes. Place the cage away from windows where headlights and outside movement reach it at night. Solve this before adding anything else to the cage.

HEAT IS THE BIGGER RISK THAN COLD

A bird is overheating if it pants with its beak open, holds its feathers sleek and flat, and holds its wings away from its body. Move it to shade or air conditioning, mist it with room-temperature water, never cold water, and call an avian vet. A bird that lives indoors should spend under 20 minutes in direct sunlight, with shade it can reach.

Air quality: fumes & feather dust

A bird's lungs make ordinary household air dangerous, and a cockatiel's own dust is a slow risk to you.

Air moves through a bird's lungs in one direction, pushed along by air sacs that keep oxygen flowing even on the exhale. That efficiency is the problem indoors: a bird pulls far more of whatever is in the air through its lungs than a person in the same room does. The rule of thumb: if you can smell it, it may harm your bird.

Nonstick cookware

PTFE (polytetrafluoroethylene) is the coating on most nonstick pans. Heated above 280°C (536°F) it releases odorless, colorless particles and acidic gases, and a pot boiling dry on the stove is the classic way it happens. Documented cases describe multiple birds dying within 30 minutes of the fumes from a single overheated pan, and the danger is not limited to birds in the same room. PTFE also turns up in drip pans, waffle irons, clothing irons, ironing board covers and some heat lamps. Cook with stainless steel or cast iron, and keep the cage out of the kitchen entirely.

Anything you can smell

SOURCE	NOTES
Aerosols	Hairspray, spray cleaners, spray deodorants, carpet fresheners, perfumes
Candles and wax melts	Scented candles irritate caged birds, and wax melts heat fragrance into the air the same way
Smoke	Tobacco, cooking smoke, fireplaces, and plastic melted in a microwave
Carbon monoxide	From any gas appliance. Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in any room with gas heat or a gas range.

Powder down and your own lungs

A cockatiel is one of the few pets with true powder down: feathers that grow continuously and flake into a fine keratin dust the bird spreads through its plumage. A white or gray film on the bars and the furniture beside the cage is normal and comes back daily. Breathing avian proteins in that dust and in dried droppings over years can cause bird fancier's lung, a form of hypersensitivity pneumonitis, in a small number of owners. Pet birds in the home raise the risk, and it tends to be diagnosed between 50 and 70. Untreated, it can scar the lungs permanently.

CUT THE DUST, AND TELL YOUR DOCTOR

Run a HEPA (high-efficiency particulate air) purifier in the bird's room, bathe or mist the bird, damp-wipe rather than dry-dust, prefer hard floors to carpet, and keep the cage out of the bedroom. If you develop a cough, breathlessness or a flu-like illness that lingers or keeps coming back, tell your doctor you keep a parrot.

Metals, pets, plants & everyday traps

The hazards that are not fumes, including two this species is known for swallowing.

Zinc and lead

Cockatiels are among the species avian vets see most often with heavy metal poisoning, so scan the cage for anything metal the bird has worked loose. Zinc poisoning, once called "new wire disease," comes mainly from galvanized cage hardware: zinc can leach off hot-dipped galvanized coatings without the bird swallowing a visible flake. Electroplated galvanized metal is considered safe; hot-dipped, the more common coating, is not. Early signs are stomach upset and appetite loss, then weakness, pale gums and discolored droppings.

Lead is just as dangerous. Curtain weights, stained glass, costume jewelry and paint in homes built before 1978 are common sources, and lead tastes sweet, so a bird that finds it keeps chewing. Signs run from weakness and an upset stomach to circling, tremors and leg paralysis. Both metals respond to treatment if caught early.

Rope and fibers

Cockatiels are noted as frequent offenders for swallowing rope fibers. Check rope perches and toys often and retire them at the first frayed strand.

A CAT OR DOG BITE IS A SAME-DAY EMERGENCY

Any mouth contact between a cat or dog and a bird needs a vet the same day, even with no visible wound. Cat saliva carries *Pasteurella* bacteria, which can cause fatal blood poisoning within hours of a bite too small to see through the feathers.

Open water, fans, windows and other animals

- **Water.** An open toilet, a full sink or a pot of hot water is a drowning or scalding risk.
- **Ceiling fans.** A flying bird cannot see spinning blades as an obstacle. Fans go off before the cage door opens.
- **Glass.** Birds do not perceive windows and mirrors as barriers and can fly into them hard enough to be hurt. Open doors and windows are an escape risk.
- **Other pets.** Cats, dogs and ferrets keep a hunting instinct toward a bird however calm they seem. Out-of-cage time is supervised, with other animals out of the room. A larger parrot should never be loose around a cockatiel.

Foods and plants within reach

A countertop within flight range is enough exposure to avocado, chocolate, onion or garlic (the full list is on page 15). Check any houseplant against a current toxic-plant list before it goes into a room the bird can reach.

Cleaning & hygiene

The daily health check hides inside the daily chore.

Every day

- Spot-clean the cage, taking out soiled paper and dropped food. Look at the droppings before they go in the bin.
- Wash the food and water bowls.
- Fresh produce comes out within a couple of hours, before it spoils in the dish.
- Wipe away the powder down on the bars and the furniture next to the cage.

At least weekly

Replace the paper or liner in the tray, more often when two or more cockatiels share the cage. Check rope toys for frayed strands and the cage for any metal the bird has worked loose.

The full clean

Move the cockatiel to a travel cage in a different room first, so it is in a separate air space while anything is sprayed or scrubbed. Strip out the old paper and every accessory. Every dropping and scrap of food comes off first with detergent, because disinfectant does little against organic debris. Then the disinfectant goes on, and most need 5 to 10 minutes of wet contact to work. Rinse until no trace of the cleaner or its smell is left, and let everything dry completely before the paper, perches and toys go back and the bird returns.

DISINFECTANT	MIX
Freshly mixed household bleach	1 part bleach to 32 parts water, about half a cup per gallon
Quaternary ammonium disinfectant	Diluted 1 to 1,000, following the label
A bird-safe habitat cleaner	Made for use around pets, not an aerosol, following the label

FUMES REACH THE BIRD FAST

A bird's respiratory system reacts to aerosolized fumes, which is why it leaves the room before anything is sprayed. Keep the room being cleaned ventilated, and never mix a disinfectant with another product.

Dust and the people in the house

Dried droppings and feather dust lift into the air when swept, so spray the floor under the cage with water before sweeping. Psittacosis can spread from birds to people (page 31). Wash your hands with soap and water after handling the bird or its equipment.

Diet: pellets, seed & how much

The single biggest lever on how long a cockatiel lives.

Commercial seed mixes are high in fat and carbohydrate but short on protein, vitamins and minerals, calcium and vitamin A among them. Worse, a bird picks its favorite seeds, sunflower and millet, and skips the more balanced parts, so what it eats is narrower than the label suggests. All-seed diets are a well-documented cause of the malnutrition commonly seen in pet cockatiels, and they are linked to fatty liver disease.

PART OF THE DIET	SHARE	NOTES
Formulated pellets	About 75 to 80% of daily intake	The foundation. A bird on this much pellet does not need vitamin or mineral supplements on top.
Vegetables and fruit	No more than 20 to 25%, by volume	Weighted toward vegetables (page 14)
Seed	A small minority	Never the base of the diet
Treats and table food	No more than about 10% of the weekly diet	Cooked lean meat, fish, egg or a little cheese is fine; nothing processed
Grit	None	Cockatiels hull their seed; grit can block the gut
Fresh water	Always	In a dish washed daily

How the day works

Cockatiels are free-choice eaters, not meal eaters. Their fast metabolism means most choose to eat through the day, so refresh the pellet bowl in the morning, when they are hungriest, and top it up if it empties before evening: it should never sit empty for long. Fresh food goes in daily and comes out within a couple of hours, before it spoils. Portions are smaller than they look: a teaspoon of food for a cockatiel is roughly a dinner plate for a person.

How much a day

A cockatiel fed seed gets about 1.5 to 2 level measuring teaspoons a day, in a shallow dish. Two birds sharing a cage get a dish each, so the lower-ranked bird still eats. Seed left over at the end of the day means too much went in, and the bird has been picking out its favorites.

On pellets, the bowl stays topped up and the bird sets its own intake. To put a number on one particular bird, use a gram scale: weigh the food going in, weigh what is left 24 hours later, and average the difference over seven days. That average is the full day's food, and it is the amount to keep offering while seed is traded out for pellets.

HENS, MOLTS AND YOUNGSTERS

Laying hens need enough calcium in the diet, since a shortfall is a direct route to egg binding (page 27). A molting bird's need for protein, calcium and iron rises sharply. A weaned youngster eats the same pellet-based diet as an adult.

Converting a seed eater to pellets

A few weeks of mild inconvenience, if it is done slowly. A real emergency risk, if it is rushed.

NEVER STARVE A BIRD ONTO PELLETS

A bird raised on seed may not recognize a pellet as food, and if the seed disappears before it does, some birds simply stop eating. The firm limits are 12 hours without food for a small bird like a budgerigar and 24 hours for an African grey. A cockatiel is a small bird with a fast metabolism: hold it to the shorter limit.

Two schedules

Both substitute gradually while the bird keeps guaranteed access to the old food. They were written for conures, but the mechanism is the same for any seed-imprinted parrot, cockatiels included.

METHOD	STEPS
Stepped	75% seed and 25% pellets for three days, then 50/50 for three days, then 25% seed and 75% pellets until the bird is fully converted.
Tapered	90% seed and 10% pellets on day one, 80/20 on day two, and so on, down to 0% seed on day 10. A bird that balks partway holds at 20% seed and 80% pellets until it converts.

If the bird stalls, hold at that ratio and let the timeline stretch. In a mature bird the change can take days, weeks or months.

What helps with a cockatiel

- **Pellets first thing in the morning**, before any other food, when the bird is hungriest and most willing to try something new.
- **Play to the ground forager**. Spread pellets on a flat surface for the bird to walk through and peck at, or tap single pellets on a table to mimic natural pecking. That can work where a bowl swap does nothing.
- **Use a moist food as a bridge**. Grind pellets to powder and mix it into a little cooked egg, mashed vegetable or soft fruit, then coarsen the pellet and reduce the moist food over time.
- **Pull the seed only once** the bird is reliably eating pellets alongside fresh vegetables and fruit.

Check these every day

SIGNAL	NORMAL DURING THE CHANGE	SLOW DOWN, OR CALL A VET
Body weight	Stable, or a small gradual dip	More than 1 to 2% lost in a week means the change is running too fast. More than 10% below the starting weight means call the vet.
Eating	Grazing on and off through the day	A bird that stops eating on schedule
Droppings	Normal size and formed	Black or minimal
Behavior	Curious, vocal and active	Quiet and puffed up

A bird whose conversion stalls completely, whose weight keeps dropping, or who develops breathing sounds along the way needs a vet exam rather than more pushing.

Vegetables, fruit & fresh food

The 20 to 25% that pellets do not cover, weighted toward vegetables rather than fruit.

Fresh food fills no more than about 20 to 25% of the daily diet by volume. Wash it and cut it small, take the seeds out of apples, and pull anything uneaten within a couple of hours to prevent spoilage and bacterial growth.

GROUP	SAFE CHOICES
Vegetables and greens	Broccoli, carrots, leafy greens, bell peppers, pumpkin, squash, sweet potato, zucchini
Fruit, in small pieces	Apple with the seeds removed, apricot, banana, blueberries, melon, mango, papaya, peach, pear, strawberries
Table food, small amounts	Cooked lean meat, fish, egg, or a little cheese. Nothing processed.

CHOOSE BY COLOR

The bright yellow, red and orange foods carry the most vitamin A: bell peppers, broccoli, carrots, sweet potatoes, squash, mango, papaya and cantaloupe. A seed diet is short on vitamin A, which makes these the foods worth offering most often.

Little nutrition

Iceberg lettuce and celery are not toxic, but they are close to empty calories: mostly water with few nutrients. They displace better food rather than adding anything, so skip them in favor of the denser choices above.

Washing

Birds are very sensitive to pesticides, chemicals and sprays. Wash all produce well and buy organic where you can. Anything from a garden that has been sprayed stays out.

Getting a suspicious bird to try something new

A cockatiel that refuses a new vegetable has not decided anything yet. Offer the same one every day for 3 to 5 days before giving up on it. Spreading food on a flat surface, as in the pellet conversion, works for fresh food too, because it matches how a ground-foraging cockatiel feeds.

The clock

Fresh food goes in when you get up and comes out a couple of hours later. Water stays available all the time, and the dish is washed daily, because a dish that has held vegetables and droppings for a day is not somewhere a bird should drink.

Treats, supplements & the never-feed list

The smallest part of the diet, and the part where the real dangers are.

Treats

Treats and table food stay small: no more than about 10% of the weekly diet. Millet is the most useful taming reward there is, offered through the bars and then from your hand (page 17), so keep it for that job rather than the food dish, and break it into small pieces. A teaspoon of anything is a big serving for a bird of about 90 g.

Cuttlebone and supplements

A cuttlebone or mineral block belongs in the cage at all times, for calcium and for the beak. A bird eating 75 to 80% of its diet as pellets does not need vitamin or mineral supplements on top. A bird still on seed, or a laying hen, is the one whose diet falls short, and the answer is the conversion and a talk with the vet rather than a jar off a shelf.

NEVER FEED

Avocado. The food most consistently flagged as toxic. Every part of the plant contains persin, a compound with documented cardiac toxicity in birds. Breathing distress typically shows about 12 hours after eating it, and death is possible within one to two days.

Chocolate. Theobromine and caffeine cause hyperactivity, tremors and potentially seizures. Darker, more bitter chocolate carries more risk.

Caffeine and alcohol, in any amount: coffee, tea and soda included.

Onion and garlic. They contain chemicals that can harm a bird's blood cells, especially in concentrated forms like garlic powder or dry soup mix.

Apple seeds, and processed food.

NO DRAMATIC ACCIDENT NEEDED

A countertop within flight range of an out-of-cage bird is enough exposure to any of the foods above. Clear the counter before the cage door opens.

The seed dish trap

A cockatiel hulls its seed and leaves the husks behind, so a seed dish can look full while holding very little. Empty the husks out before deciding the bird has food. A bird still eating mostly seed needs the conversion on page 13, not a bigger dish.

Weight, body condition & the daily scale

A cockatiel hides illness under its feathers. Weight is the vital sign that does not.

A gram scale catches what your eyes and hands cannot. Weight loss shows on a scale days to weeks before a bird looks thin, sick or fluffed up, because feathers hide body condition extremely well. A bird that eats normally can still be quietly losing mass, which is exactly how avian gastric yeast works (page 33).

WHAT	TARGET
Typical adult weight	80 to 125 g, about 90 g on average. Your bird's own settled weight is what matters.
How often	Every day, at the same time, before breakfast, on the same scale. Write the number down.
Scale	A kitchen scale that reads in single grams. A perch fitted to it makes the habit easier.
During a diet change	Daily without fail. A loss of more than 1 to 2% in a week means the change is too fast; more than 10% below the starting weight means call the vet.
Obesity	Roughly 20% over the bird's ideal weight, a body condition score of 4 out of 5. In a 90 g bird that is about 18 g, invisible without the scale.

A trend, not a number

A single reading tells you almost nothing. A logged trend, taken at the same time of day on the same scale, tells you a lot. A vet asking what the bird normally weighs is not making conversation: a few grams over a month in a bird this size is a finding, and a bird with no history is a guess. The Owner Log on page 44 is built for it.

Feeling the keel

Weight alone does not say whether it is muscle, fat or a full crop. Body condition scoring in birds is built around the keel: the blade-like ridge of breastbone down the center of the chest, with the flight muscles attached on either side. It is assessed by feel, not by eye, on a scale from 1 (emaciated) to 5 (obese).

WHAT THE FINGER FINDS	WHAT IT POINTS TO
A subtle ridge, with muscle rounded out on either side	Good condition
A sharp, prominent keel with little padding	Underweight
A keel you can barely find, cushioned in fat	Overweight

DO NOT CHASE A NUMBER

The value of the keel check is tracking the same bird over time. A keel that has gotten sharper since last month is the signal. The nine-point scale used for dogs and cats does not transfer to birds.

Handling & taming

Trust first, technique second. It goes faster when the bird sets the pace.

Let it settle first

A new cockatiel needs a genuine adjustment period: give it 7 to 14 days with no handling attempts. Feed it, change the water, sit near the cage and talk softly. If other birds already live in the house, those days overlap quarantine (page 24), and the new bird is handled last each day.

The progression

Move to the next step only once the bird is calm at the current one.

1. **Treats through the bars.** Sit near the cage, talk softly, and offer millet through the bars.
2. **Hand in the cage.** Once that is comfortable, offer the treat with your hand inside the cage, held still.
3. **Step-up.** Offer a flat palm with your fingers pointing down and your thumb tucked in, or a handheld perch, as the surface to step onto. Avoid a single upright finger: most birds find it awkward to grip and are more likely to bite it than step onto it.

Keep sessions short, 10 to 15 minutes is plenty, and let the bird's comfort decide how quickly you move forward rather than a fixed timeline.

LATER RUNG	WHAT IT BUYS YOU
Target	The bird touches a stick with its beak on cue: a way to move it anywhere without grabbing it
Step up and step down	Handling without a chase, in and out of the cage
Recall	A bird that comes back to your hand on cue, which is what makes a flighted bird manageable
Carrier and towel	A calm bird at every vet visit, and an easy nail trim or exam

Each rung is built the same way: a marker, a small reward such as a flake of pellet or a sunflower seed, and a short session ended while the bird is still interested.

NEVER CHASE A LOOSE COCKATIEL

A panicked, exhausted bird can collapse, or fly into a window hard enough to injure itself. Forcing the moment also sets back the trust you have been building, which matters more than winning any one evening.

Where to touch

Head and neck. A bird can read stroking along the back, rump or hindquarters as mating behavior, which is one of the triggers for chronic egg laying in a hen (page 26). A trusting cockatiel is also simply easier and safer to handle for routine jobs like cage cleaning, nail trims or a vet visit.

One cockatiel or two

A decision that shapes every other one.

Cockatiels are flock birds and need regular interaction to stay well-adjusted. A single bird with excellent toys and no company is still a single bird, and the daily time commitment for a solo cockatiel is substantial: the number to plan around is an hour or more out of the cage every day. A solo bird can live happily without another cockatiel on one condition: daily attention from its people, with toys and a radio or television for the hours in between.

	ONE COCKATIEL	A PAIR
Company	You are the flock. A single cockatiel handled every day already has its companion in its keeper.	Two birds of the same sex usually bond to each other and lose interest in people.
Time	An hour or more out of the cage with you, every day	Still an hour or more out of the cage each day, which is what keeps a cockatiel socialized
Cage	Sized for one bird	Larger than a single-bird cage, because cage minimums are quoted per bird
Eggs	A lone hen can still lay	Two males are the easiest pairing and bring no eggs. A male and a female will try to breed.

The middle path

A second bird in its own cage gives company without taking over the bond you have with the first. No choice of sex guarantees the two will get along, because wild cockatiels pick their own mates. The companion that works is another cockatiel: a bird of a different species gets its own cage.

Adding a second cockatiel

1. A vet exam for the new bird, then the full quarantine in a separate room, where the resident can hear the newcomer but not see it.
2. Both cages in one room, close enough to see each other but not to reach. Move them closer over the following days while both stay calm. Two birds that choose the perches nearest each other and interact through the bars are ready for the next step.
3. A neutral cage that neither bird has claimed, with the first days together closely supervised.

Beak sparring and squabbling over perches are normal. Pulled feathers or any blood mean the birds are separated for good. Through all of it, give the resident extra attention with the newcomer in view, so the new arrival reads as a bonus and not a replacement. Full acceptance takes weeks to months.

ANSWER THIS HONESTLY FIRST

Will this bird get an hour or more out of the cage with you every day, on the busy weeks as well as the easy ones? If yes, one bird handled daily is a full life. If the honest answer is "some days," plan for two.

Body language & reading the crest

The crest is real information, and it is one cue among several.

The crest

Cockatiels, cockatoos and hawk-headed parrots raise and lower their crest feathers to show their emotional state. Cockatiels erect the crest to show excitement, in response to good and bad things alike. The crest tracks mood only in a general way, so read it alongside posture and feather fluff before deciding what it means.

CREST	WHAT IT USUALLY GOES WITH
Relaxed and upright	A calm, comfortable bird
Held back and relaxed	Contentment
Raised erect, or swept sharply forward	Excitement or startled alertness: something changed
Flattened tight to the head, body rigid	Fear or aggression. Back off now.

Stress: stop and wait

Hissing. A flattened or agitated crest. Lunging.
Tail-flicking. Fluffed feathers with rapid breathing.
Scrambling to the far side of the cage. Neck-stretching.

Comfort: carry on

Soft chirps. Preening while you are there. Beak grinding. A relaxed, upright crest.

Fluffed and relaxed, or fluffed and sick

CHECK	FLUFFED AND RELAXED	FLUFFED AND POSSIBLY ILL
Duration	Minutes, then the feathers sleek back down	Hours, or most of the day
Feet	One foot, the other tucked up	Standing flat on both feet
Activity	Still interested in food, toys and people	Uninterested, quiet, withdrawn
Position	Normal perch height	Low on the perch, or on the cage floor

Cues worth knowing

- **Beak grinding** is a soft scraping sound a comfortable bird makes, often just before sleep.
- **Eye pinning**, the pupils flashing wide and narrow, marks arousal, good or bad. Watch the rest of the bird before a hand goes near its face.
- **Tail bobbing** timed to each breath is a bird working harder to breathe: a same-day vet visit, not a mood.
- **Regurgitating** food onto a favorite person, mirror or toy is a bonding behavior, distinct from vomiting, which sticks to the face and chest feathers.

Enrichment & common mistakes

Cockatiels finally have research of their own, and it points at the food bowl.

Two studies now look at enrichment in cockatiels specifically. A 2020 study examined the effects of environmental enrichment on cockatiels in aviaries, and a 2025 study concludes that environmental enrichment improves behavior and welfare in captive cockatiels, with reduced feather-damaging behavior singled out. Across parrots, food offered in a regular bowl produces foraging times of less than an hour a day, which leaves most of the day unoccupied.

Priority order

1. **Food delivered through foraging rather than a bowl.** Start easy: a bird that has only ever been bowl-fed does not know food is inside a device, so the first stage is food left in plain sight on top of a toy. Increase difficulty as it learns, and keep an eye on intake.
2. **Company**, whether a compatible bird or a real daily routine with you.
3. **Varied perch diameters and materials**, at different heights and distances.
4. **Shreddable material, rotated:** paper, softwood and palm. Material that survives the week has not done its job.
5. **A bath offered daily**, in the morning so the feathers dry before night: a shallow dish of lukewarm water or a gentle mist, with a spritz once or twice a week for a bird that will not bathe on its own. Regular bathing also keeps less powder down in the air.
6. **An hour or more out of the cage daily**, supervised, in a room checked for hazards.
7. **Novel objects, last.**

Common mistakes

THE MISTAKE	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
Seed as the base of the diet	Pellets at 75 to 80% (page 12)
A tall, narrow cage bought for its looks	Buy width, with bars half an inch apart or closer
A pitch-dark room and no night light	A small night light or a cover against night frights
A hut, nest box or mirror for company	Take it out; it is a laying trigger
The same toys left up indefinitely	Rotate them; a solved puzzle left up for a month is furniture
A hard first foraging toy	Start with food in plain sight; a bird that cannot solve it eats less
A big cage treated as occupation	A large cage with a food bowl still leaves a bird with nothing to do
Sandpaper perch covers	Remove them; they damage feet

PLUCKING IS A VET VISIT FIRST

Do not assume plucking is behavioral before an avian vet has ruled out medical causes, or before ruling out a normal molt.

Flight & wing clipping

You will be asked about this in week one, usually by whoever would do the trim.

The facts are mostly settled: a clip is feathers, not amputation; it grows back at the molt; a correct trim leaves controlled descent; and an incorrect one is dangerous. What is genuinely unsettled is a values call, and it belongs to you and your vet.

What a clip is

A clip shortens the primary flight feathers along the outer edge of the wing, so the bird cannot gain or hold altitude. A correct trim removes four to seven of the outermost primaries on both wings, cut below the covert feathers that overlay them. The secondary feathers closer to the body are left alone, because they let the bird slow down and control a landing. Both wings always get the same trim. Only mature feathers are cut: a growing blood feather has a live blood supply in its shaft, which is the main reason a vet does the trim.

COCKATIELS FLY FAST AND LAND BADLY

A cockatiel clipped too short cannot slow itself down and crash-lands on hard floors, which injures the keel or the skin just behind the vent. A correct trim still leaves the bird able to flutter down under control. Check the landing before you leave the clinic.

THE CASE FOR CLIPPING	THE CASE AGAINST
Reduces the risk of flying into windows, mirrors or ceiling fans	Flight is a bird's main exercise, and a safe flighted home can make trimming unnecessary
Lowers the odds of an escape through an open door in a busy household	Loses a major route to heart and muscle conditioning
Can make early taming manageable for a new or nervous owner	A poor trim risks falls that injure the keel or beak
Some clipped birds become more accepting of hand training	A bird more accepting because it is less able to leave has not been trained

What clipping does not do

- **It does not guarantee a bird cannot fly.** A tailwind, a draft or feathers that have grown back can give enough lift to reach an open door.
- **It does not treat behavior.** Biting, screaming and hormonal behavior have their own causes.
- **It is not permanent.** Every clipped feather regrows at the next molt, and molt is not on a fixed calendar. Treat a clip as a decision revisited each molt.

TRAIN A RECALL EITHER WAY

A bird that reliably returns to your hand on cue can be out of its cage without every open door being a live risk, which is what makes keeping a cockatiel flighted a realistic option (page 17).

Nails, beak, blood feathers & first aid

A cockatiel weighs about 90 g, and that changes how much blood it can spare.

Nails

How often nails need trimming depends more on what the bird stands on all day than on a calendar, so check the bird in front of you. Every toenail has a blood vessel and nerve running partway down it, the quick, and the longer the nail, the further it extends. On a light nail it shows as a pink area; on a dark nail, a flashlight held behind it helps. Take a little at a time. If you cut the quick, keep the bird safely restrained, pinch the toe from side to side just above the cut, press styptic powder to the nail end, and keep the bird away from its water dish for several hours so the clot is not disturbed.

Beak

AN OVERGROWN BEAK IS A SYMPTOM

A healthy bird with enough to chew rarely needs a beak trim. An abnormally long beak is most commonly caused by chronic malnutrition or liver disease, and overgrown beak and nails together can point to the liver. A beak that keeps coming back means a vet workup, not another trim.

Broken blood feathers

A blood feather is one still growing in, with an active blood supply through the shaft. A bird carries very little blood for its size, and one that has snapped a blood feather can lose a lot in a short time.

- **Do not pull it at home.** It leaves the shaft open and can cause more blood loss; even a vet pulls one only as a last resort.
- **Shaft snapped, base still seated:** blot the broken tip and press styptic powder, cornstarch or plain flour onto the exposed end. Never pack powder into an open follicle.
- **Feather torn out completely:** that is an open wound. Use firm, steady pressure with clean gauze and get the bird to a vet.
- **If it has not stopped in two to three minutes,** call an avian vet at once.

A new feather forms in the same follicle and matures in roughly four to six weeks.

The towel

Teach the towel before you need it, in short, reward-paired sessions, so the bird steps into a toweled hand rather than being chased with one. Keep a session short and stop the moment the bird shows real distress rather than mild annoyance. If its breathing becomes labored or it weakens, return it to the cage at once.

First aid kit

The six items for a small bird's kit are on the setup checklist (page 36). Check the kit twice a year. The most useful item in it is your avian vet's number.

Choosing a cockatiel

Most of what makes or breaks a bird-owning household is decided before the bird comes home.

The commitment

A cockatiel typically lives 12 to 15 years, and up to about 25 has been reported. Match that span to your own life stage and your household's long-term stability, not just to how appealing the bird looks in the store. Be honest about daily time too: a cockatiel needs an hour or more out of the cage every day, not just a full dish. The bird itself is the cheap part of owning one (page 38).

Hand-raised or parent-raised

A hand-raised bird is pulled from the nest partway through development and fed by a person. A parent-raised bird stays with its parents through weaning and meets people afterward. Hand-raised birds usually step up more readily and bond with people faster. That tameness has a cost: Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006), studying African grey parrots, linked hand-rearing to more frustration-related behavior disorders, including aggression and feather picking, and to more dependence on people. Most hand-raised birds live fine lives, and the study was in greys, not cockatiels. A parent-raised bird takes longer to tame but starts from a more typical baseline.

Where to get one

SOURCE	ASK
Breeder	To see the parent birds; whether the chick was hand-raised or parent-raised, how old it was when it left the nest, and whether it is weaned; about diet and health issues in their line. Visit in person rather than having a bird shipped.
Pet shop	A shop's birds usually come from several breeders, which mixes health histories. Ask how long the bird has been in the store, whether a vet has examined it, and whether new arrivals are quarantined away from the birds already on the floor.
Rescue	A first option, not a fallback. Ask about the bird's history and any known behavior problems before taking it home.

Assessing the bird in front of you

Watch the whole cage before you focus on one bird. A healthy cockatiel is lively, alert, interactive and attentive: it tracks movement around the room, responds to sound, and interacts with its cage mates or surroundings. Its feathers lie smooth and it moves around rather than sitting in one spot the whole time you watch.

DO NOT TAKE THIS ONE HOME

A bird that stays fluffed and still, sits with its eyes half closed during the day, or does not react when you approach the cage is not the bird to take home, even if it is the only one left. If one bird looks off compared with the others, ask the seller what they have seen.

THE VET VISIT IS PART OF THE PURCHASE

A bird can look fine in a cage on a single visit and still carry something a shop, a breeder or your own eye missed. The first exam also gives you a baseline to compare against later.

Quarantine @ the first vet visit

A new bird can look completely normal for weeks while carrying something that would spread through a flock in days.

How long, and where

Thirty days is the floor. It applies to every newly acquired bird, including one that has been to a show, and to a household with no other bird yet, because the habit matters most on the day there is a second bird to protect. Plan on 30 to 45 days in a separate room while the bird is screened. For a multi-bird household or an aviary, run nearer 90 days, because an infected adult can shed polyomavirus on and off for up to 90 days.

RULE	WHY
A separate room with its own door, kept shut	Isolation means separate air space, not a second cage in the same room
Its own dishes, perches, toys and cleaning tools	A shared dish, sponge or scoop can carry bacteria or a virus across the gap
Established birds first, the new bird last	Healthy before isolated, every day, so nothing on your hands reaches the birds you are protecting
Wash your hands between birds	With soap and water, or change gloves. Feathers, dander and dried droppings travel on clothing too.

MEDICINE IS NOT A SHORTCUT

Routine preventive antibiotic treatment is discouraged: it can harm the bird and encourage resistant bacteria. Antibiotics are for a confirmed case of psittacosis (page 31), not for skipping quarantine.

The first exam

It belongs inside quarantine, within one to two weeks of bringing the bird home, so results are back before the new bird meets anyone. It starts with a physical exam: the bird is weighed, its mouth checked, and its heart and breathing listened to. The tests are chosen from there:

- Blood work: a complete blood count and a chemistry panel covering calcium, protein and organ function.
- A fecal exam for intestinal parasites, and swabs of the mouth and vent for abnormal bacteria or yeast. Ask for the fecal check specifically: cockatiels carry *Giardia*, which does not show to the naked eye.
- Screens for psittacosis, polyomavirus and PBFD (psittacine beak and feather disease), as the bird's history calls for. A PCR (polymerase chain reaction) test can detect infection in a bird that still looks healthy, and because shedding comes and goes, one negative result is not a clean bill of health.
- Whole-body X-rays, which need sedation or gas anesthesia, sometimes.

Finding the vet

At a minimum, choose a member in good standing of the Association of Avian Veterinarians, whose find-a-vet search lists members by location. Find the vet before the bird comes home. After the first visit, one checkup a year is the floor, and many avian vets recommend two.

Sexing by plumage & the color exceptions

One of the few parrots you can sex by looking, in one color, after one age.

Cockatiels are a real exception among parrots: in the right bird, looking works. There are two things to read, not one.

	COCK	HEN
Face	A bright, clean yellow forehead, throat, crest and cheeks, with vivid orange ear patches	Much less yellow, a duller, grayer face
Under the wings and tail	Solid black	A barred pattern

The underwing and tail are the more reliable half, because they are a pattern rather than a judgment of brightness. If the face and the wing disagree, trust the wing.

Limit one: age

Until maturity at about 6 months, every young cockatiel is colored like a hen, bars under the wings included. A bird under six months tells you nothing, and a "hen" bought as a chick can turn out to be a cock after its first molt.

Limit two: color

The cue is clearest in the standard gray, the wild-type bird with the yellow face and orange cheeks, and most pet cockatiels are not that bird. The method works by contrasting the yellow and orange against the gray and black, so any mutation that removes or scrambles either pigment removes the cue with it.

COLOR	WHY THE VISUAL METHOD FAILS
Lutino	No dark pigment left to make the barring or the black underwing readable
Whiteface	No yellow or orange to brighten
Albino	A whiteface lutino: neither pigment
Pied	Both pigments scattered at random; the hardest of all to call
Pearl	A pearl hen keeps her pearling while a cock usually molts his away: a clue, not an answer

DNA testing is the actual answer

For any of those birds, and for confirming a visual guess before it matters, a DNA test is the answer. A blood sample or a plucked feather is sent to a lab, directly or through your avian vet. A 2023 study found blood the more accurate of the two, because it carries more DNA than a feather or a mouth swab, though a feather is the easier sample to collect at home.

WHY IT MATTERS

A hen can lay with no male anywhere in the house, and repeated laying is the most common serious problem in this species (page 27). An owner who believes the bird is a cock does not notice a laying cycle starting.

Hens, hormones & chronic egg laying

A single hen with no male in the house can lay, and repeated laying is what harms her.

Chronic egg laying, egg binding, soft or shell-less eggs and oviduct prolapse are all common in cockatiels, even in a single hen with no male present. The likely reason is where the species comes from: wild cockatiels live in arid Australia and come into breeding condition only when food and water are plentiful, and a pet with a full bowl lives in permanently good times. Of all the small parrots, the cockatiel is the one this comes up in most.

Maturity	6 to 12 months
Clutch	3 to 8 eggs, 5 on average
Incubation	19 to 21 days

What chronic laying costs her

Each clutch drains the calcium used to build eggshells. The low blood calcium that follows, hypocalcemia, shows as weakness, lethargy, brittle bones that can fracture during normal handling, egg binding, seizures and death.

The triggers: take away as many as you can

- **A long day.** A long photoperiod is one of the major triggers. Protect the 10 to 12 hours of dark first (page 8).
- **Abundant, unlimited rich food.** A steady surplus mimics the conditions for raising a wild clutch.
- **A nest-like space:** a dark enclosed hideaway, a nest box, a corner of the cage floor.
- **A mate, or something treated as one:** a mirror or a favorite toy.
- **Petting.** Stroking the back, rump or hind end reads as mating. Keep contact to the head and neck while she is laying.

DO NOT PULL THE CLUTCH

Removing each egg as it appears prompts her to lay more to replace it. Leave her to sit on a completed clutch, real or dummy eggs, for a full incubation, which for a cockatiel is 19 to 21 days. Then remove the eggs gradually, roughly one every one to two days, rather than all at once. Take away the nest-like furnishings, mirrors and favorite toys at the same time.

Light, diet and the vet

Cutting daylight or room light to 8 hours a day, or 8 to 10 as a short-term measure, can reduce the stimulus to lay. It is one tool among several, to run with an avian vet. Seed-based diets are short on calcium, selenium and vitamins D and E, so a pelleted diet with proper calcium and a cuttlebone are standard advice for a chronic layer. For a hen that keeps cycling anyway, an avian vet has hormonal options: an injection that stops laying for three to four weeks and is repeated on a schedule, or an implant under the skin that lasts three to six months or longer. Neither replaces removing the triggers.

Egg binding

A hen who cannot pass an egg has hours, not days. This is the page to know by heart.

Egg binding is an egg that forms but fails to pass and lodges in the oviduct, the tube an egg travels down. It is where chronic laying stops being a management problem and becomes a same-day emergency. Small birds can die within a few hours of becoming egg-bound, as the trapped egg compresses circulation and presses on the air sacs. A hen kept alone can bind, so the risk exists whether or not you breed her.

STAGE	WHAT TO WATCH FOR
Early	Depression, closed eyes, sitting low or on the cage bottom, and no egg passed in 48 hours by a hen that may be laying
Progressing	Weak and not perching, straining as if to lay or pass a dropping, noticeable abdominal swelling
Advanced: act now	A bobbing tail and labored breathing, an egg bulging at the vent or a prolapse, or a hen unable to stand or grip the perch, because the egg presses on the nerves to her legs

WHAT TO DO, IN ORDER

1. Call an avian vet now, the same day and ideally the same hour. There is no home remedy that safely dislodges a bound egg, and waiting for tomorrow's appointment is never the right call.
2. Keep her warm on the way. A sick bird recovers best at 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C): a warm room and a covered carrier, with no open flame.
3. Do not try to squeeze or work the egg out yourself.

What the vet will do

A mildly affected hen may respond to supplemental heat, injectable fluids, calcium, vitamin D3 and oxytocin, a hormone that makes the oviduct contract and helps push the egg out. A severe case can need the egg's contents drawn out with a needle passed through the vent, or surgery.

Why it happens

Without enough calcium, the oviduct cannot contract hard enough to push the egg out, and cockatiels are prone to low dietary calcium. Obesity from a high-fat, all-seed diet is another cause, alongside hereditary factors, old age and an unsuitable place to lay.

Preventing the next one

- A pelleted diet with proper calcium, and a cuttlebone or mineral block always available.
- Light cut back when a hen is cycling, and a quiet, dark sleep every night.
- No nest-like furnishings, no mirror, and no petting down the back.
- Weight kept in check, and a vet visit for a hen who is laying heavily, thin and slow to recover between clutches, before anything gets stuck.

Molt & seasonal changes

Normal, uncomfortable, and mistaken for illness often enough to learn.

What a normal molt looks like

Birds normally lose and replace most of their feathers at least once a year, and many also run a smaller partial molt about six months after the main one. Timing is not fixed: nutrition, sunlight, day length and humidity all move it. A normal molt is slow and gradual, and the feathers that come out are whole and undamaged, not shredded or snapped off partway. New feathers start as pin feathers, growing feathers in a waxy sheath that stays soft while the feather is supplied with blood, then dries and flakes away as it matures. Most birds work the dry sheaths loose through ordinary preening. Molting is demanding, and the pin feathers can be uncomfortable, so an easygoing cockatiel can turn cranky for a stretch. A bird that suddenly does not want to be handled is usually just having a grumpy molt. A heavy molt is also one of the reasons a cockatiel goes off its food, because growing a full set of feathers raises the need for protein, calcium and iron sharply. Keep weighing: a drop is still a drop.

A NORMAL MOLT	PAST A NORMAL MOLT
Slow, with whole, undamaged feathers shed gradually	Bald skin appearing quickly, or feathers that look chewed, pinched or stunted
New pin feathers coming in as old ones drop	Missing patches, or loss from a spot the bird cannot reach, such as the top of its head
Scattered across the body	Loss only where the beak reaches
A quieter, touchier bird	A bird fluffed on the cage floor, off its food, or unwell

Helping through a molt

- **Keep the daily bath going.** Bathing or misting softens the sheaths and encourages the preening that works them off.
- **Do not pull a pin feather.** A growing one carries a blood supply (page 22).
- **Expect grumpiness** and handle less while it lasts.

Seasonal changes

Day length is the seasonal signal a cockatiel reads, and an indoor bird under household lighting can be pushed into breeding condition at any time of year. It becomes a problem when the environment holds a hen in that state, which is why the light schedule comes before anything else (page 26). Heat is the other season to plan for. A parked car can climb 20°F in as little as 10 minutes and 50°F in an hour, and a bird is never left in one (page 42).

WING FEATHERS GROW BACK AT THE MOLT

A clipped flight feather regrows the next time that feather is molted out, so the molt is also when a trim stops working. Which month that is cannot be predicted from the calendar.

Red flags & finding a vet

A cockatiel hides illness until it cannot. By the time it looks sick, it has been sick a while.

Wild cockatiels live in flocks where predators single out the weakest-looking bird, so hiding illness is hardwired, not a choice. A cockatiel can mask sickness well enough that owners often notice nothing until the illness has progressed. This page exists to move the moment you notice it earlier, and the daily weighing and droppings check are how.

SAME DAY, NOT A FEW DAYS OF WATCHING

Discharge from the eyes, nose or mouth, or bubbles from the beak.

Tail-bobbing with each breath, labored breathing, or clicking breathing sounds.

Sitting on the floor of the cage instead of perching.

Feathers fluffed for long stretches, or sleeping fluffed on two feet.

A hen straining, sitting low, or with no egg passed in 48 hours.

Bleeding that has not stopped after two to three minutes of pressure.

Any mouth contact from a cat or dog, even with no wound.

A noticeable, sustained drop in eating alongside any other sign here.

Call the vet soon

- A change in the droppings that lasts more than 24 hours: color, consistency, number or amount.
- Weight trending down over several weighings, or more than 10% below the bird's own baseline.
- Vomiting, which sticks to the face and chest feathers. Regurgitating onto a toy or a person is courtship, not illness.
- New feather damage, bald patches, or unkempt, ratty-looking plumage from neglected preening.
- Listlessness, or any sudden change in appetite or behavior.

Normal numbers worth knowing

Body temperature	About 107°F (41.8°C). Far higher than a mammal's, and not measured at home.
Heart rate	Roughly 206 beats a minute at rest
Breathing	40 to 50 breaths a minute at rest
Weight	80 to 125 g, about 90 g on average; stable against the bird's own baseline
Droppings	One about every 20 to 30 minutes while awake

Using the vet well

Avian vets are a specialized field, and the nearest one may be some distance away, so locate one before an emergency forces the search. Annual wellness exams are worth doing even when nothing seems wrong. When something is wrong, have ready today's weight and the usual weight, what the bird eats, how long the sign has lasted, and a phone photo of the droppings. Write the vet's number and an after-hours number on the emergency card today.

Vitamin A, calcium, obesity & fatty liver

The most common preventable illness in pet birds, and it starts in the food dish.

Nutritional disease from a seed-heavy diet is the most common preventable illness in pet birds. Birds that eat only seeds, especially sunflower seeds and peanuts, are the most prone, and diet is the common thread running through most of the conditions in this section.

Vitamin A deficiency

Hypovitaminosis A is a vitamin A deficiency that shows across several body systems. Standard seed mixes provide vitamin A well below what a cockatiel needs.

WHERE IT SHOWS	SIGNS
Nose, eyes and airway	Nasal discharge, sneezing, swelling around the eyes, conjunctivitis, labored breathing
Kidneys	Drinking and urinating more
Feathers	Poor feather quality, feather picking
Appetite	Loss of appetite

The fix is the diet: pellets, and the bright yellow, red and orange vegetables (page 14).

Calcium deficiency

Calcium deficiency, sometimes leading to a condition called nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism, is common, and cockatiels are noted as especially prone to it. It shows as weakness, unsteadiness, tremors, depression, seizures, and bones that break with no real injury. A laying hen spends calcium on every eggshell, which is why she runs short first (page 26). Keep a cuttlebone or mineral block in the cage at all times.

Obesity and fatty liver disease

A high-fat, seed-heavy diet combined with limited activity leads to obesity, and an all-seed diet is linked to hepatic lipidosis, fatty liver disease. Obesity means roughly 20% over the bird's ideal weight, a body condition score of 4 out of 5 on the keel: in a 90 g cockatiel that is about 18 g, which only the scale shows (page 16).

THE BEAK AND NAILS CAN BE THE CLUE

An abnormally long beak is most commonly caused by chronic malnutrition or liver disease, and an overgrown beak and overgrown nails together can point to the liver. A beak that keeps growing back needs a vet workup, not another trim.

THE WHOLE PREVENTION PLAN

Pellets at 75 to 80% of the diet, vegetables daily, seed as a small minority or a training reward, a cuttlebone in the cage, and an hour or more out of the cage every day.

Breathing problems & psittacosis

Fast-moving, and one of them can pass to the people in the house.

Any breathing sign in a cockatiel is urgent. Learn the normal while the bird is healthy: 40 to 50 breaths a minute at rest, with the tail still. Tail-bobbing with each breath, labored or open-mouth breathing, clicking sounds, bubbles from the beak and nasal discharge all carry the same message: a same-day vet visit.

CAUSE	WHAT POINTS TO IT
An inhaled toxin	Sudden onset with nothing wrong beforehand. Nonstick fumes, aerosols, smoke (page 9).
Vitamin A deficiency	Nasal discharge, sneezing and swelling around the eyes in a seed-fed bird
Egg binding	Labored breathing in a hen, because the trapped egg presses on the air sacs (page 27)
Psittacosis	Below

Psittacosis

Psittacosis, also called parrot fever or avian chlamydiosis, is caused by the bacterium *Chlamydia psittaci*. It is zoonotic, meaning it can pass to people in the household. In a cockatiel it tends to show as breathing trouble or conjunctivitis, and in some birds gray feathers turn black. Lime-green droppings, in both the stool and the urates, are another pointer, because it is a common cause of liver disease in birds.

- **A healthy-looking bird can carry it.** Some infected birds look healthy and shed the bacterium only on and off, which is why a bird that looks clean on day 10 of quarantine can still test positive later.
- **Treatment** is the antibiotic doxycycline, for a confirmed or strongly suspected case, on the course your vet sets. It is never a preventive shortcut.
- **For people**, cleaning the cage is the exposure. Spray the floor with water before sweeping so dried droppings do not lift into the air, and wash your hands after handling the bird or its equipment.

WHILE YOU GET TO THE VET

Keep the bird warm, around 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C), in a covered carrier, with as little handling as possible. Stop any spraying, cooking or cleaning in the house. If a fume exposure is suspected, get the bird into fresh air first and call from outside.

A COUGH IN THE HOUSE

If a person in the house develops a cough, breathlessness or a flu-like illness that lingers, tell the doctor there is a parrot at home. Psittacosis is one reason, and bird fancier's lung from the feather dust is the other.

Beak and feather disease & polyomavirus

The two viruses quarantine and testing are largely built around.

Psittacine beak and feather disease

PBFD is caused by a circovirus that attacks the fast-growing skin cells behind the beak and the feather follicles, so both grow visibly wrong. It occurs mainly in parrots native to Africa, Australia, New Zealand and Indonesia, which puts the Australian cockatiel in its range, and it is rare in macaws, Amazons and conures.

- **Feathers** look stunted, club-shaped or pinched off, changing symmetrically across the body, with feathers lost even where the bird cannot reach, such as the top of the head. Powder down can fail too.
- **The beak** can grow long, flaky or oddly shiny, and break with ordinary handling.
- **Outlook:** there is no cure, and most affected birds eventually die of secondary infections.
- **Spread:** direct contact, feather dust, dander and dried droppings. A young bird can carry it for a long time with no signs, which is why a PCR test belongs in quarantine.

Avian polyomavirus

This virus is two diseases under one name, and the gap between them is mostly the bird's age at infection.

WHO	WHAT HAPPENS
Unweaned chicks	Signs appear 7 to 10 days after exposure: lethargy, and a crop that stops emptying. Death follows within 24 to 48 hours. Mortality can reach 100% in birds under 15 days old, and many die with no signs at all.
Older survivors	Outside budgerigars, birds past the youngest age may show no obvious signs, or show bleeding and clotting problems instead.
Adults	Typically resistant to the disease, but can shed the virus on and off for up to 90 days, and a recovered bird can remain a carrier with no signs.

The virus travels mainly in feather dust and droppings, and also in urine, urates and secretions from the airway and crop. A licensed vaccine exists for selected parrots. In its efficacy study in cockatiels, the first dose went in at 35 days of age, with a second 2 to 3 weeks later; breeding birds get two doses two weeks apart in the off-season. Which schedule fits a given bird is a vet's decision, and a fair question to ask a breeder.

DO NOT GUESS FROM A PHOTO

Feather changes from either virus can look like a molt or like plucking. An avian vet tests for both directly, with a PCR (polymerase chain reaction) test on blood, swabs or feather dander.

Giardia, gastric yeast, rope & metal

Two gut infections this species is known for, and two things it is known for swallowing.

Giardia and other gut flagellates

Giardia and its relatives are motile parasites living in the lower intestine, linked to diarrhea in cockatiels. They do not show in the droppings to the naked eye: the vet finds them by looking at the droppings under a microscope, and treats with an antiparasitic drug. The first exam is the natural time to ask for that check.

THE ITCH THAT LOOKS LIKE A HABIT

An infected cockatiel may have loose stools, or may instead be intensely itchy and attack itself, especially under the wings. Plenty show only the itch, with a normal-looking tray the whole time, and from across the room that looks exactly like a stress or boredom habit. A cockatiel plucking or digging at its skin, particularly under the wings, gets a fecal test before anyone rearranges the cage.

Avian gastric yeast

Avian gastric yeast, once called megabacteriosis, is a yeast, *Macrorhabdus ornithogaster*, not a bacterium. Budgerigars, parrotlets, lovebirds, cockatiels and finches are the small pet birds most often affected, and at least one case series found it more often in cockatiels than in budgerigars.

- **The pattern:** a bird that keeps eating on schedule, keeps its feathers smooth, and still loses weight by the gram. Whole or partly digested seed in soft droppings is another flag. The only reliable early catch is the daily scale.
- **Diagnosis** is a fresh dropping under the microscope. The yeast sheds on and off, so one negative result does not clear a bird.
- **Outlook** varies widely: 10 to 80% of affected birds die, depending on the bird and the strain.
- **Treatment** is a 30-day course of an antifungal drug from the vet. Failures are common when the course runs shorter, most often because the bird looked better and the owner stopped.

Rope fibers and heavy metal

Cockatiels are noted as frequent offenders for swallowing rope fibers and heavy metal objects: curiosity plus a beak built for exploring. Matted fibers can block the gut, so rope toys come out at the first frayed strand. Metal is the other risk, and the zinc and lead sources and signs are on page 10. Both metals respond to treatment if caught early, so a cockatiel with weakness, an upset stomach or tremors and no obvious cause deserves a vet's look for metal.

Feather plucking & feather loss

A vet visit and environmental changes, in that order. Most owners work this list backwards.

A bird missing feathers sends most owners straight to the scariest answer. Compare what you see against a normal molt first (page 28), then use the one built-in limit of plucking: a bird can only chew, pull or over-preen feathers its own beak can reach.

	WHAT THE FEATHERS LOOK LIKE	WHERE	FIRST MOVE
Normal molt	Whole feathers shed gradually, new pin feathers coming in	Scattered across the body	Bathe or mist; let it run
Plucking	Chewed, ragged or pulled out	Only where the bird can reach; the head is spared	Vet visit, then environment and behavior
Giardia	Damaged by self-attack	Commonly under the wings	Fecal test (page 33)
PBFD	Stunted, club-shaped or pinched, changing symmetrically	Includes places the bird cannot reach	Avian vet diagnosis; no cure (page 32)

THE HEAD TELLS YOU

Bald or damaged feathers on the chest, back or under the wings with a full set on top of the head is very likely self-inflicted. Feather loss on top of the head while everything else looks fine is not plucking, because the bird cannot reach that spot.

Work the list in this order

1. **Is it plucking at all?** Use the table above.
2. **Medical.** The underlying cause is not always obvious from outside, and for a cockatiel the fecal test for Giardia comes before anything else. Environmental fixes help only once medical causes are ruled out.
3. **Boredom, loneliness and stress.** These are the causes plucking is most often traced back to. Move food into foraging, increase time out of the cage, and look honestly at company (page 20).
4. **Sleep and hormones.** Protect the 10 to 12 hours of dark (page 8), and remove mirrors and nest-like spaces.
5. **Handling.** Consistent, patient handling goes a long way toward preventing the boredom and stress behind it.

THE COCKATIEL EVIDENCE

A 2025 study concludes that environmental enrichment improves behavior and welfare in captive cockatiels, and it singles out reduced feather-damaging behavior as an outcome. The changes that help are the ordinary ones: foraging, company, varied perches, things to shred and a daily bath.

Reading droppings & water

The one health check that costs nothing and happens by itself every 20 to 30 minutes.

A normal dropping is three outputs mixed together, because a bird's digestive, urinary and reproductive tracts all empty through one shared opening, the vent. The **feces** are the solid, formed part, green or brown. The **urates** are the white or cream, chalky part: uric acid, which lets a bird excrete nitrogen while conserving water. The **urine** is the clear liquid ringing the rest.

PART	NORMAL	GENUINE RED FLAG
Feces	Green to brown, shifting with diet, sometimes red or orange on colored pellets	Black or tarry, bright red or blood-tinged, or watery with no formed stool
Urates	White to cream	Bright yellow or lime green, especially if the stool turns lime green too
Urine	Clear, a small ring	Large volumes on every dropping, or a marked drop in how often the bird goes
Texture	Solid, curled, holds its shape	Undigested whole seed, pea-soup consistency, or bubbles

What the red flags can mean

- **Lime-green urates and stool** together point to psittacosis (page 31).
- **Undigested seed** in soft droppings can mean avian gastric yeast (page 33).
- **Red or black droppings** can mean lead poisoning, which causes bloody urine.

Polyuria is not diarrhea

Polyuria is extra clear liquid around an otherwise normal, formed stool: plain excess urine, often from stress, a diet change or a lot of fresh fruit or vegetables, and on its own usually not an emergency. **True diarrhea** is the fecal part itself turning mushy or semi-liquid, and it shows up alongside several serious conditions. One wrinkle: polyuria with no obvious dietary cause can be the first sign of kidney disease from zinc poisoning.

THE 24-HOUR RULE

Once you know your bird's normal, any deviation counts, and if it lasts longer than 24 hours it is a same-day call to an avian vet. Call sooner for blood in a dropping, black or tarry droppings, a bird that has stopped producing droppings near its normal frequency, or any change paired with a fluffed-up, quiet or off-food bird.

The habit, and water

Line the tray with plain paper and look at it at the same time each day. Note anything unusual with a date, even as a phone photo. Water must be there, clean, all the time, in a dish washed daily.

Setup checklist & targets

Print this one. Audit an existing setup against it, or buy against it.

The cage

- ☐ At least 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm); 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) for easier movement; wider rather than taller
- ☐ Bars half an inch (1.3 cm) apart or closer, running vertically
- ☐ Stainless or powder-coated; nothing galvanized (page 10)
- ☐ Against a wall, off drafts, out of direct sun, away from windows that flash at night
- ☐ Not in or near the kitchen, and not in your bedroom
- ☐ Night light in the room, or a cage cover (page 8)
- ☐ Plain paper on the tray, with a grate

Diet and equipment

- ☐ Pellets about 75 to 80% of the diet; vegetables and fruit no more than 20 to 25%
- ☐ Seed a small minority; treats under about 10% of the week
- ☐ Fresh water, dishes washed daily

First aid kit

- ☐ Styptic powder (cornstarch or flour as a backup)
- ☐ Nail clippers sized for a small bird
- ☐ Clean gauze squares

Inside the cage

- ☐ Perches of varied diameter and texture, about 5/8 to 1.5 in (1.6 to 3.8 cm)
- ☐ Dishes placed where droppings cannot fall in
- ☐ Cuttlebone or mineral block, always available
- ☐ Foraging and shreddable toys, rotating
- ☐ No nest-like hideaway, no mirror, no sandpaper perch cover
- ☐ No grit, and no frayed rope

- ☐ Gram scale reading in single grams; weigh daily
- ☐ Travel carrier and first aid kit ready
- ☐ Avian vet found; number on the emergency card
- ☐ Nonstick cookware replaced; aerosols and scented products out of the bird's air

- ☐ A small hand towel kept for this
- ☐ A small flashlight or phone light
- ☐ Avian vet and emergency clinic numbers

Targets at a glance

Room temperature	About 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C); no drafts, no direct sun
Darkness	10 to 12 hours, quiet and uninterrupted, at the same clock time every night
Weight	80 to 125 g, about 90 g on average; stable against the bird's own baseline
Out-of-cage time	An hour or more a day, supervised, in a room checked for hazards
Vet	A first exam within 1 to 2 weeks, then at least once a year; many avian vets advise twice

Emergency & quick targets

CALL AN AVIAN VET NOW IF

The bird is on the cage floor, or fluffed for long stretches · tail bobbing with each breath, labored breathing or clicking · discharge from the eyes, nose or mouth · bleeding that does not stop in two to three minutes · a hen straining, sitting low, or no egg passed in 48 hours · any mouth contact from a cat or dog · collapse or a suspected fume exposure (fresh air first) · a sudden change in appetite or behavior.

TARGET	VALUE
Cage and bars	At least 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm), 24×24×30 in (61×61×76 cm) for easier movement; bars half an inch (1.3 cm) or closer
Room temperature	About 70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C)
Sick or recovering bird	75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C)
Darkness	10 to 12 hours, with a night light; 8 hours of light is the managed step to break a laying cycle, with a vet
Diet	75 to 80% pellets, no more than 20 to 25% fresh food, seed a small minority
Weight	80 to 125 g. During a diet change, slow down at 1 to 2% lost in a week; call the vet at 10% below the starting weight.
Quarantine, new bird	30 to 45 days in a separate room; nearer 90 for a multi-bird household
Nonstick danger point	Above 280°C (536°F), reached by a pot boiling dry

Your numbers

Avian vet _____ Baseline weight (g) _____
 24-hour emergency clinic _____ Last vet visit _____
 Bird's name and hatch date _____ Next due _____

GETTING THERE

Use a compact carrier with a low, secured perch or a padded floor, belted into the back seat, partly covered. Keep the bird warm, and never leave it in a parked car (page 42). Bring the weight log, a droppings photo and the diet.

Budget & shopping list

United States retail ranges, last checked in September 2026. Treat them as a snapshot, not a quote.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
The bird itself, varying by color mutation	\$75 to \$250
Cage: a flight cage about 31×20×53 in (79×51×135 cm)	\$190 to \$286
Perches	\$10 to \$25
Food and water dishes	\$10 to \$18
Toys	\$10 to \$22
Complete starter setup, bird included	\$295 to \$601

ONGOING, ONE BIRD	TYPICAL COST
Food and supplies: a pellet-based diet with fresh food, toys and upkeep, averaged	about \$17 to \$29 a month
Annual routine total: food, toy replacement, cage upkeep	\$200 to \$350 a year

PLAN FOR, DO NOT COUNT ON AVOIDING

Avian exams come on top of every figure above: one when the bird comes home and at least one a year after that, with many avian vets recommending two, and fecal testing or blood work adds to each visit. Reproductive emergencies like egg binding arrive with no warning. Pet insurance for birds is uncommon, so most owners cover vet costs directly: keep a dedicated emergency fund.

NOT PRICED IN THE TABLES

The avian vet exams, a gram scale, a travel carrier, a night light or cage cover, a cuttlebone or mineral block, and a first aid kit are all worth buying and none is in the setup range above. A pellet-based diet with fresh food costs more than seed alone, and it is the healthier choice.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

The cage. It is often the biggest single line, more than the bird, and a too-small cage becomes a welfare problem, not just an inconvenience. The bird is the smallest number here; the cage and the vet care decide the lifetime cost.

First 30 days

In order. Most of the first two weeks is doing less than you want to.

Before the bird arrives

- ☐ Cage built, stocked and sited before pickup day (page 6)
- ☐ Avian vet found and the number written down (page 24)
- ☐ Quarantine room ready if you already keep birds
- ☐ Nonstick cookware replaced, aerosols and candles moved out (page 9)
- ☐ Night light in the bird's room (page 8)
- ☐ Gram scale, carrier, pellets and a cuttlebone in the house

Days 1 to 7: let it settle

- ☐ No handling. Food, water, cleaning, and sitting near the cage talking softly (page 17)
- ☐ Look at the droppings every morning; they are the first thing to go odd (page 35)
- ☐ 10 to 12 hours of dark from night one, at the same time nightly
- ☐ Weigh before breakfast every day and write the number down (page 16)

Days 8 to 14

- ☐ First avian exam, within one to two weeks of arrival, with a fecal check
- ☐ Millet through the bars once the bird has settled
- ☐ Offer the same vegetable daily for 3 to 5 days before giving up on it (page 14)
- ☐ A foraging toy with food in plain sight on top (page 20)

Days 15 to 30

- ☐ If the bird came on seed, begin the pellet conversion, weighing daily (page 13)
- ☐ Hand in the cage with millet, then the flat-palm step-up, 10 to 15 minutes at a time
- ☐ Check one room for hazards and take the first out-of-cage session there (page 10)
- ☐ Daily bath offered in the morning
- ☐ End of quarantine at 30 to 45 days, if you keep other birds; then the introduction stages (page 18)

WHAT NORMAL LOOKS LIKE BY DAY 30

Eating and drinking, droppings consistent, weight steady, preening and chirping, sleeping on one foot, and grinding its beak softly at bedtime, which is contentment.

Symptom quick reference

What you see, what it might be, and how fast to move. A cockatiel that has visibly changed has been unwell a while, so when in doubt, call.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MIGHT BE	ACT
On the cage floor, or fluffed for hours	Serious illness of almost any kind; egg binding in a hen (page 27)	Same day
Tail bobbing, labored breathing, clicking, bubbles	Infection, psittacosis, an inhaled toxin, vitamin A deficiency (page 31)	Same day
Collapse, or sudden distress after cooking or spraying	Nonstick or aerosol fumes (page 9)	Now; fresh air first
Straining, sitting low, no egg in 48 hours	Egg binding	Now
Thrashing in the cage at night	A night fright (page 8)	Check for injuries; add a night light
Bleeding	Broken blood feather, nail, cage injury (page 22)	Pressure; vet if not stopped in 2 to 3 minutes
Mouth contact from a cat or dog	Fatal blood poisoning from <i>Pasteurella</i> , even with no wound	Same day
Nasal discharge, sneezing, swelling around the eyes	Vitamin A deficiency; infection (page 30)	Vet soon
Weakness, tremors, a fracture from nothing	Calcium deficiency, often in a laying hen; heavy metal	Same day
Eating well but losing weight; whole seed in droppings	Avian gastric yeast (page 33)	Vet soon
Lime-green or bright yellow urates	Psittacosis; liver disease	Vet soon
Black, tarry or bloody droppings	Bleeding; lead	Same day
Watery droppings, solid part formed; or a mushy fecal part	Polyuria (stress, a diet change, watery food, or kidney disease with no obvious cause) or true diarrhea (page 35)	Call after 24 hours
Plucking or digging under the wings	Giardia first, then behavior (page 34)	Fecal test
Overgrown beak or nails	Liver disease or malnutrition, not a grooming problem	Vet workup
Feathers abnormal or missing on the head	Not self-inflicted: PBFD or polyomavirus (page 32)	Vet soon
Symmetrical loss with pin feathers coming in	Normal molt (page 28)	Monitor
Regurgitating onto a toy, mirror or hand	A bonding behavior and a hormonal signal, not vomiting	Remove the object
Vomit stuck to the face and chest	Illness, not courtship	Vet soon
A whistler gone quiet, or a tame bird refusing to come out	Any illness: a change in a habit is a symptom	Vet soon

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Ten minutes of care, an hour or more of company, and a few jobs that keep the rest working.

Every day

- ☐ Weigh before breakfast; log it (page 16)
- ☐ Spot-clean; read the droppings (page 35)
- ☐ Fresh water; wash the bowls
- ☐ Refresh the pellet bowl in the morning (page 12)
- ☐ Fresh food in, and out again within a couple of hours
- ☐ Bath offered in the morning
- ☐ Wipe away the powder down near the cage
- ☐ An hour or more out of the cage in a checked room, and a short training session
- ☐ Lights out at the same hour; night light on

Every week

- ☐ Replace the tray paper at least weekly
- ☐ Rotate the toys; hide food a new way
- ☐ Check rope for frayed strands and the cage for loose metal
- ☐ Look at nails and beak

Every month

- ☐ Full clean, with the bird in another room (page 11)
- ☐ Review the weight log as a trend
- ☐ Re-check the room: new candles, sprays and cookware arrive quietly

Every year

- ☐ Wellness exam, twice if you can; check the first aid kit twice a year

Seasonal

WHEN	WHAT CHANGES
Long days	Longer days push birds toward breeding condition. Hold the indoor light schedule steady and watch a hen for laying behavior (page 26).
Hot weather	A caged bird cannot leave the sun, so check for a moving sunbeam. Keep the bird in shade and never leave it in a parked car.
Molt	A quieter, touchier bird that may eat less for a while. Keep bathing, keep weighing and handle less (page 28).
Cold weather and outages	No candles, kerosene or propane heaters, or gas oven for warmth. Cover the cage and move it to the warmest interior room.

Power outages, heat, travel & transport

For a bird, the danger in a blackout is usually what people light, not the cold.

THE OPPOSITE OF THE REPTILE PLAN

A cockatiel is warm-blooded and carries almost no energy reserve between meals. During an outage, keep food and water in front of it the whole time, checked and refilled by hand if anything depends on power. A bird that goes off food during a stressful outage is a reason to call the vet, not to pull the bowl.

During an outage

- No candles, no kerosene or propane heater, no gas stove or oven used for heat, in any room the bird is in. Flashlights and battery candles beat open flame, and a battery light covers the night light too.
- A generator runs outside, at least 20 feet (about 6 meters) from doors, windows and vents, and never in or near a garage, house or shed. An open window is not enough.
- Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in any room with gas heat, a gas range or a nearby generator. People need levels above about 70 parts per million before they feel anything, and a bird has no such buffer.
- For warmth, cover most of the cage with a thick towel or blanket, leaving a gap for airflow, and move it to the warmest interior room. A wrapped hot water bottle goes near the cage, never touching it. A sick bird does best at 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C).

Hot weather

A bird indoors should spend under 20 minutes in direct sunlight, with shade it can reach. An overheating bird pants with its beak open, feathers sleek and flat, wings held away from its body. Fluffed feathers are the opposite signal: cold or sick. Move it to shade or air conditioning, mist it with room-temperature water, never cold, and call an avian vet on the way.

Travel and the carrier

WHAT TO DO	
The carrier, not the cage	A compact carrier with a solid or padded floor and a low, secured perch, belted in or strapped. A full cage's shape and hanging dishes do not secure well.
Stress	Cover part of the carrier with a light, breathable cloth and keep one side open for air.
Never a parked car	A cabin can climb 20°F in as little as 10 minutes and 50°F in an hour, so a 75°F day puts it near 95°F by the time a quick stop becomes a checkout line. The bird comes in with you.

WRITE IT DOWN BEFORE THE POWER GOES OUT

The vet's number and the nearest 24-hour exotics clinic belong on the emergency card and the sitter sheet, not in your head.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE CAGE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through a real feeding and cage check before the first solo visit.

Bird's name _____

Avian vet _____

Cock or hen; normal weight (g) _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

My phone _____

Backup contact _____

Every day: feeding comes first

A missed meal is not acceptable "just this once": a cockatiel has almost no reserve.

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Fresh water; wash the bowls, do not just top up. | ☐ Change the paper on the tray. Glance at the droppings first: a green or brown coil, white urates, a little clear liquid. |
| ☐ Pellet bowl refilled each morning; it should never sit empty. Kept at _____. | |
| ☐ Fresh food in the morning: _____ Take it out after a couple of hours. | ☐ Lights out at _____ and on at _____, for 10 to 12 hours of dark. Leave the night light on. |
| ☐ Treats: _____, small pieces only. | ☐ Talk to the bird. Ten minutes near the cage counts. |

Please don't

- Use a nonstick pan, candle, space heater, aerosol or scented product anywhere in the house while the bird is here.
- Turn off the night light. This species panics in the dark and can hurt itself on the bars.
- Let the bird out of the cage unless we have arranged it, or let another animal into the room.
- Feed avocado, chocolate, onion, garlic, caffeine or alcohol, in any amount.

CALL ME, OR THE VET, IF

The bird stops eating · sits fluffed and unresponsive, or on the floor of the cage · breathes with an open beak or its tail bobs with each breath · there are no droppings, or far fewer · there is blood anywhere · there is an egg, or a hen is straining: leave any egg where it is and call. If you cannot reach me, call the vet.

Where the pellets and cleaning things are _____

Anything else _____

Owner log

Weight is the vital sign that moves before anything else is visible. Write the number even when it is boring: the boring numbers are what make one interesting number readable. During a diet change, more than 1 to 2% lost in a week means slow down. Take this page to the vet.

Equipment & vet log

Equipment log

ITEM	REPLACED	NEXT DUE	NOTES
Perches			
Rope toys and perches checked for fraying			
Cuttlebone or mineral block			
Night light bulb			
Pellet bag opened			
Air purifier filter			
First aid kit checked (twice a year)			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Month 1 is whichever month you start in.

TASK, BY MONTH	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Full clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Weight trend reviewed	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Room hazard re-check	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Wellness exam	☐					☐						☐
First aid kit checked			☐						☐			

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS	TREATMENT AND FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ Perches of varied diameter and material, at different heights and distances
- ☐ Shreddable material: paper, softwood, palm
- ☐ A cuttlebone or mineral block
- ☐ Part of the daily ration in a foraging toy (page 20)

Each week

- ☐ Rotate the toys; make the foraging a little harder as the bird learns
- ☐ Replace shredded material: anything that survives the week has not done its job
- ☐ A bath offered every morning
- ☐ Short training sessions ended on a win (page 17)
- ☐ An hour or more out of the cage each day, in a checked room

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

IF THE SAME BEHAVIOR KEEPS SHOWING UP

Feather plucking and screaming beyond normal contact calls mean enrichment is not covering the bird's needs, or that it is unwell. Check both, and with a cockatiel start with the vet.

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to L

Avian gastric yeast	A yeast (<i>Macrorhabdus ornithogaster</i>), once called megabacteriosis, that disrupts digestion: a bird eating well and still losing weight. Page 33.
Avian polyomavirus	A virus that kills unweaned chicks and that adults can carry and shed with no signs. A vaccine exists for selected parrots. Page 32.
Bar spacing	The gap between cage bars: half an inch (1.3 cm) or less for a cockatiel. A head-entrapment limit. Page 6.
Bird fancier's lung	A form of hypersensitivity pneumonitis in people: an immune reaction to bird proteins in feather dust and dried droppings, breathed in over years. Page 9.
Blood feather	A feather still growing, with a blood supply running up the shaft. Breaking one can bleed heavily in a bird this small. Page 22.
Circovirus	The family of virus behind PBFD. Page 32.
Clutch	The eggs a hen lays in one run: 3 to 8 for a cockatiel, 5 on average. Page 26.
Contact call	A loud call a flock bird makes to locate the others when they are out of sight. The cockatiel's sharp call and wolf whistle are this. Page 5.
Crest	The movable feathers on top of a cockatiel's head, raised and lowered with its emotional state. Page 19.
Crop	The pouch at the base of a bird's neck where food is held. A crop that stops emptying is a serious sign. Page 32.
Cuttlebone	The calcium-rich internal shell of a cuttlefish, kept in the cage for calcium and for the beak. Page 7.
DNA	Deoxyribonucleic acid: the genetic code. A DNA test on a blood sample or a feather sexes a bird whatever its color or age. Page 25.
Doxycycline	The antibiotic used to treat a confirmed or strongly suspected case of psittacosis. Never a preventive. Page 31.
Egg binding	A formed egg the hen cannot pass. A same-day emergency. Page 27.
Fecal check	A vet's microscope check of a dropping for parasites such as Giardia, and for yeast. Page 24.
Giardia	A gut parasite that infects cockatiels and can cause loose stools, an intense itch, or both. Page 33.
Hand-raised	Pulled from the nest and fed by a person. Usually tamer, and more dependent on people. Page 23.
HEPA	High-efficiency particulate air: a filter standard for air purifiers that traps very fine dust, including powder down. Page 9.
Hepatic lipidosis	Fatty liver disease: fat building up in the liver, linked to an all-seed diet. Page 30.
Hypocalcemia	Low blood calcium. Chronic laying drains calcium into eggshells and can cause weakness, fractures and seizures. Page 26.
Hypovitaminosis A	Vitamin A deficiency, from a seed-heavy diet. It shows in the nose, eyes, airway, kidneys and feathers. Page 30.
Keel	The blade of breastbone down the center of the chest. Felt, not seen, to score body condition. Page 16.
Lutino	A color mutation with no dark pigment: a yellow and white cockatiel that cannot be sexed by plumage. Page 25.

Glossary, M to Z

Molt	The gradual replacement of feathers, at least once a year. Slow, with whole feathers and no bald skin. Page 28.
Night fright	Sudden, panicked flapping in the dark that can injure a cockatiel on the bars. A night light or cover helps prevent it. Page 8.
Nutritional secondary hyperparathyroidism	A bone condition that a long calcium shortfall can lead to. Cockatiels are especially prone to the calcium deficiency behind it. Page 30.
Oviduct	The tube an egg travels down. Without enough calcium it cannot contract hard enough to push an egg out. Page 27.
Oxytocin	A hormone a vet may give an egg-bound hen to make the oviduct contract. Page 27.
<i>Pasteurella</i>	Bacteria in cat saliva that can cause fatal blood poisoning in a bitten bird within hours. Page 10.
PBFD	Psittacine beak and feather disease: a circovirus that stunts feathers and damages the beak. No cure. Page 32.
PCR	Polymerase chain reaction: a lab test that detects a germ's genetic material, even in a bird that looks healthy. Page 24.
Pellets	A formulated food that packs balanced nutrition into every bite. About 75 to 80% of the diet. Page 12.
Photoperiod	Hours of light per day. A long photoperiod is a major trigger for chronic laying. Page 8.
Pied	A color mutation that scatters the pigments at random. The hardest cockatiel of all to sex by plumage. Page 25.
Pin feather	A new feather in its waxy sheath. Tender, and worked loose by preening. Page 28.
Polyuria	Extra clear urine with the solid fecal part still formed. Different from diarrhea. Page 35.
Powder down	Feathers that grow continuously and flake into a fine keratin dust. Cockatiels, cockatoos and African greys make it. Page 9.
Primary feathers	The long outer flight feathers. A wing clip shortens four to seven of them on each wing. Page 21.
Psittacosis	Parrot fever, or avian chlamydiosis, caused by <i>Chlamydia psittaci</i> . It can spread to people. Page 31.
PTFE	Polytetrafluoroethylene: the nonstick coating on many pans. Above 280°C (536°F) it releases particles and gases that kill birds. Page 9.
Quarantine	Keeping a new bird apart, in a separate room on separate equipment, for 30 to 45 days. Page 24.
Units	°F, degrees Fahrenheit, and °C, degrees Celsius, for temperature; in (inches), ft (feet) and cm (centimeters) for size; g (grams) for weight; % (percent) for shares of the diet.
Urates	The white or cream chalky part of a dropping: uric acid, how a bird excretes nitrogen while saving water. Page 35.
UV	Ultraviolet: light beyond what the eye sees. 10 to 12 hours a day of UV exposure supports a cockatiel's vitamin D. Page 8.
Vent	The single opening that droppings and eggs both leave through. Page 35.
Whiteface	A color mutation with no yellow or orange, so the face cue for sexing is gone. Page 25.
Zinc poisoning	Poisoning from galvanized cage hardware, once called "new wire disease." Page 10.
Zoonotic	Able to spread from animals to people. Psittacosis is. Page 31.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary references

- Veterinary Centers of America (VCA Animal Hospitals): the cockatiel feeding and general information pages, fruits and vegetables in bird diets, common conditions of pet birds, egg binding, chronic egg laying, sexual behavior, new bird visit, bathing birds, abnormal droppings, recognizing illness, household hazards, zinc poisoning, polyomavirus, PBFD, respiratory disease, nursing care, beak and nail care, blood or pin feathers, wing clipping, taming and training, clicker and target training, and transporting your bird pages.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: nutritional diseases, toxicoses, reproductive diseases and disorders, viral, mycotic, digestive and miscellaneous diseases, skin and feather disorders, management, behavior and illness of pet birds, the overview of pet birds (cage size and bar spacing) and the popular pet birds table.
- Lafeber and LafeberVet: the cockatiel basic information sheet (weight, length, life span, maturity, clutch, incubation, weaning, body temperature, heart and breathing rates, cage size, bar spacing, perch diameter, household temperature, sexing); reading bird body language; psittacine behavior, handling and restraint; body condition scoring; the healthy-weight article by avian veterinarian Susan Orosz; reproductive emergencies; grooming companion birds; foraging and enrichment; switching from seeds to pellets; foods toxic to pet birds; cat bites; summer heat; and the cockatiel, molting, pin feather, hissing, second cockatiel, screaming and droppings answers.
- Association of Avian Veterinarians: the find-a-vet directory. University of Florida Small Animal Hospital: how to care for your pet bird. University of California, Davis, School of Veterinary Medicine: feather-picking in parrots.
- Bird Vet Melbourne: caring for cockatiels. Melbourne Bird Vet: *Macrorhabdus*. New Plymouth Vet Group: feeding a cockatiel. Niles Animal Hospital and Bird Medical Center (veterinarian Peter S. Sakas): megabacteriosis. Chicago Exotics Animal Hospital: polyoma virus. Teresa L. Lightfoot, avian veterinarian: chronic egg laying.

Research

- Applied Animal Behaviour Science: the 2020 study of environmental enrichment in cockatiels kept in aviaries, and the 2025 study on enrichment, behavior and welfare in captive cockatiels. Schmid, Doherr and Steiger (2006), AFA Watchbird: the breeding method and adult behavior of African grey parrots.
- Turcu and colleagues (2023), Animals: feathers and oral swabs as DNA sources for molecular sexing. A 2023 case series on avian gastric yeast in cockatiels, budgerigars and grey parrots (PubMed Central). Kila and colleagues (2025), Cureus: a case report of bird fancier's lung. Ungurean and colleagues (2021), Current Biology: pupil behavior in birds.
- AnAge, the animal ageing and longevity database: the 35-year cockatiel record (Brouwer and colleagues, 2000). United States Department of Agriculture, Animal and Plant Health Inspection Service: the summary of studies for the avian polyomavirus vaccine.

Public health and safety

- National Association of State Public Health Veterinarians: the compendium of measures to control *Chlamydia psittaci* infection, 2009, for the 30-day quarantine floor, the cleaning dilutions and contact times, and no preventive antibiotics. California Department of Food and Agriculture: pet bird care and disease prevention. National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute: hypersensitivity pneumonitis.
- Consumer Product Safety Commission and Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: carbon monoxide. National Weather Service: car interior heating.

Husbandry and cost

- PetMD: the cockatiel care sheet (cage, UV light, sleep), getting a second bird, the most popular pet birds, and how long birds live. The Vet Desk and Hepper: cockatiel costs. Retail prices were last checked in September 2026 at PetSmart and other retailers.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Life span	12 to 15 years, up to 25 reported (a veterinary information sheet); 10 to 14, a documented maximum of 24 (a veterinary hospital page); 15 to 25, the oldest reported at 36 (a pet-health site); a 35-year record (a longevity database)	12 to 15 years, up to about 25, the record 35. The species sheet carries the typical range.
Minimum cage	At least 20 to 24 in long and wide (a veterinary sheet); about 20×20×30 in (a veterinary reference table); 24×24×30 in for easier movement (keepers)	20×20×30 in minimum, 24×24×30 in for easier movement
Bar spacing	0.5 to 0.75 in (a veterinary sheet); half an inch or smaller (a veterinary reference table)	Half an inch or smaller: the stricter figure, because the risk is head entrapment
Incubation	19 to 21 days (the cockatiel sheet); 21 to 28 days (parrots in general)	19 to 21 days for a cockatiel
Fresh share of the diet	No more than 20 to 25% (the cockatiel feeding page); larger shares in some general bird pages	No more than 20 to 25%
Weight loss during a diet change	More than 1 to 2% in a week means too fast (a university hospital); more than 10% from the start means call a vet (a veterinary page)	Slow down at 1 to 2% a week; call the vet at 10%
Time without food	12 hours for a small bird like a budgerigar; 24 hours for an African grey	12 hours, the small-bird limit
Checkups	At least yearly; many avian vets advise twice a year	Once a year is the floor; twice is stronger
Quarantine	30 days is the floor (a public health compendium); 30 to 45 days; 90 days for an aviary (polyomavirus shedding)	30 to 45 days; nearer 90 with other birds
Crest meanings	A raised crest signals excitement, good or bad (a veterinary handout); no fixed position-by-position dictionary is documented	General meanings only, read with posture and fluff (page 19)
Wing clipping	Safety against escape and collisions; flight as the main exercise (veterinary sources weigh both)	The owner's decision with a vet; both cases on page 21

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.0 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 51 pages. Safety: perch diameters about 5/8 to 1.5 in (1.6 to 3.8 cm), where 1.3 said 1/2 to 3/4 in; an egg-bound or sick bird kept at 75 to 80°F (24 to 27°C) on the way to the vet, where 1.3 said about 80°F; 10 to 12 hours a day of UV light exposure, or safe supervised time outdoors; cage minimum 20×20×30 in, 24×24×30 in for easier movement, with vertical bars; a seed-fed bird gets 1.5 to 2 level teaspoons of seed a day; during a pellet conversion, no more than 12 hours without food, slow down at 1 to 2% lost in a week, call the vet at 10%; leave a hen's completed clutch for the full 19 to 21 day incubation; cage disinfected with bleach at 1 part to 32 parts water. Costs: setup \$295 to \$601 with the bird included, and \$200 to \$350 a year for food, toys and upkeep with vet exams on top, where 1.3 said \$392 to \$1,027 with a scale, carrier, sleep cage and first exam, and \$285 to \$550 a year with the exam. Removed: medicine doses and exam prices, and the candida, scaly face mite, bumblefoot and goiter entries, which the site's cockatiel and bird guides do not support. Other changes are wording only.
- **1.3, Oct 2026.** Outside sources named in the care text rewritten as plain statements. Other changes are wording only. Replaced by 3.0.
- **1.2, Oct 2026.** Safety: a bath offered daily; two cocks, not two hens, named as the pairing with no eggs; quarantine 30 to 45 days, up to 90 for an established flock; an hour or more out of the cage daily; daily weighing, with a 1 to 2% weekly limit during a diet change; sick-bird warmth at 80°F; the 24-hour droppings rule. Costs: yearly upkeep \$200 to \$350 before the exam. Replaced by 1.3.
- **1.1, Sep 2026.** Safety: a broken blood feather gets firm pressure and is never pulled at home; egg-binding warmth 80 to 85°F; multi-bird quarantine 90 days; no fixed interval for wing feather regrowth. Replaced by 1.2.
- **1.0, Sep 2026.** First edition. Replaced by 1.1.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for an avian veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home.

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